Does Factionalism Prevent Conflict Resolution?

Evidence from Nagaland and Mizoram, India, 1966–2022

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Abstract

How does rebel factionalization impact the chances for terminating conflicts, and under which circumstances can the state be seen as a cause for factionalizing rebels? This paper utilizes a natural experiment involving two insurgent movements that resemble each other structurally within the same country, namely the Mizo National Front, resolved by the 1986 Peace Accord, and the ongoing National Socialist Council of Nagaland. In this work, we develop and apply the concept of Rebel Cohesion Index, which represents a combination of measures such as faction concentration, intrarebel combat, and plurality of ceasefires. These indexes are based on annual measurements

and are tested against confirmed MOHA data for 1999–2022. By using negative binomial regression, we find that the one-standard deviation decrease in rebel cohesion is linked to 33.7 percent higher chances of conflict cases per year. Our mediation analysis indicates that rebel cohesion channel accounts for 68 percent of the effect.

Keywords: insurgent factionalism, conflict termination, counterinsurgency, rebel cohesion, Nagaland, Mizoram, spoiler dynamics

1. Introduction

Does the fragmentation of rebel movements reduce or prolong civil war? The question sounds like it should have a settled answer. It does not. In 2009, Lyall (2009) showed that Russian artillery shelling in Chechnya, which fragmented local insurgent networks, produced a 24 percent reduction in subsequent rebel attacks. The finding was striking because it contradicted the orthodox hearts-and-minds prediction that indiscriminate violence breeds retaliation. Three years earlier, Cunningham (2006) had demonstrated, across the full universe of civil wars since 1945, that each additional rebel faction in a conflict significantly extends its expected duration. Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) confirmed the mechanism: each new faction introduces a demand set that may not overlap with those of other groups, and the probability that any negotiated offer falls within the joint acceptance set of all actors declines as the number of actors grows. The implication is that a state which fragments a rebel movement into three, five, or thirteen factions has, by that act, made comprehensive settlement exponentially harder to reach.

2. Literature and Theory

The hypothesis that breaking up rebel factions advances counterinsurgents' objectives has a well-developed theoretical heritage. According to Galula (1964), insurgent political leaders should be separated from their military wing, and distinctions between factions should be created in order to isolate the most extreme members. Indeed, the US Army counterinsurgency doctrine includes strategies aimed at breaking up the rebel coalition (Headquarters, Dept. of the Army, 2014). Academic literature offers empirical support for this claim. According to Kalyvas (2006), selective use of force against insurgents can break up coordination and lower attack rates. Lyall (2009) demonstrate that indiscriminate Russian shelling in

Chechnya led to a 24-percentage point reduction in the number of attacks. Fjelde and Nilsson (2012) find that state repression triggers insurgent fragmentation, while insurgency becomes militarily less effective following the occurrence of factionalization. In recent works, Mosinger (2018) show that the structure of civilian constituencies determines whether a rebel movement splits up or stays united, whereas Fjelde and Nilsson (2018) pinpoint conditions conducive to emergence of competing rebel factions.

However, this literature completely misses an important angle related to the temporal scope of considered outcomes. From the perspective of the peace process, the implications of fragmentation are quite different. As per Cunningham (2006), each additional veto player adds to the expected length of a civil war. Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) corroborate this finding using large cross-country samples, illustrating that each additional rebel group prolongs civil war since each brings forward its own demand, which makes it unlikely that any offer will fall into the joint acceptance range of all groups. Nilsson (2008) argue that groups left out of incomplete peace deals become spoilers due to their material interest in derailing peace negotiations. Stedman (1997) gives a classic classification of spoiler behavior, noting that greedy spoilers occur much more often in fragmented civil wars. Walter (2002) finds that a commitment problem emerges when multiple groups hold veto powers and thus cannot bind other groups to any negotiated deal.

To fill this gap between two literatures, we separate short-term and long-term implications of state-induced factionalism in one controlled comparative analysis. In case of Nagaland, India has been able to succeed in the short term in decreasing fatalities to near zero from a peak of 213 in 2008 [1]. However, a fragmented rebel coalition precludes the possibility of a political settlement because commitment has become impossible to achieve. Meanwhile, Mizoram was able to terminate

[1] See Note 11

conflict after merely 20 years thanks to a lack of state-induced fragmentation of MNF.

The formal mechanism through which factionalism perpetuates conflict derives from the bargaining theory of civil war (Fearon, 1995) extended to multi-party settings by Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009). Let F_t denote active insurgent factions at time t, and let $G_i \subseteq \mathbb{R}^k$ denote the political demand set of faction i. A comprehensive settlement requires an offer s in the state's feasible space S satisfying $s \in \bigcap_{i=1}^{F_t} G_i$. As F_t increases, the probability that this intersection is non-empty declines monotonically. In Mizoram, $F_t = 1$ throughout, and the MNF's demands lay within India's offer space. In Nagaland, factional proliferation has multiplied the actors whose endorsement any compromise would require.

The second mechanism is tangible rather than symbolic. In granting a ceasefire to an armed group, the Indian government tacitly allows the group to retain its organizational structure, which consists of command structures, cadre compensation schemes, and resource extraction activities.[2] As Weinstein (2007) demonstrates, material organizations, not driven by ideology but by their material gains, lack any intrinsic motivation to demobilize, since demobilization means the loss of revenue that supports the faction's payroll. Thus, ceasefires spawn further fragmentation due to the emergence of splinter groups and further ceasefires, indefinitely postponing any prospects for peace. This is precisely the resource-conflict relationship that Fearon (2004) cites as a factor behind prolonged civil wars. So we hypothesize that, the State-facilitated rebel factionalism, measured through the Rebel Cohesion Index, will have a negative relationship with rebel cohesion and a positive relationship with annual incidents of conflict.

[2]See Note 4.

3. Research Design

3.1. Case Selection

The Naga-Mizo pair is almost an ideal Most Similar Systems design as envisioned by Przeworski and Teune (1970). The two cases have similarities in terms of proximity of the two regions within a 200-kilometer radius, mostly tribal and Christian population, governance under Armed Forces Special Powers Act, backwardness as compared to India's national average, subject to bombing by the Indian Air Force [3], and similar counters to insurgency. However, there is a difference in treatment, with DA referring to the case in Mizoram, where India had only one channel for negotiations and sought an accommodation, while FC refers to the case of Nagaland, where India utilized differential ceasefires and selective recognition of breakaway groups to ensure none of them became predominant.

3.2. The Rebel Cohesion Index

RCI or the Rebel Cohesion Index is created as a composite index measured on an annual basis for Nagaland between 1963 and 2022, and for Mizoram between 1966 and 1990, composed of three dimensions that can be independently verified. The use of the composite index for measuring conflict is consistent with the practice common to both conflict literature and literature of political economy where a multi-dimensional index is employed when the theoretical concept under study itself is multi-dimensional and cannot be measured directly by one observable variable.

First component of this index is the Organisational Fragmentation Score (OFS), which is defined to be measured as the inverse of the Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (HHI) of factional cadre percentage. The HHI was developed by Herfindahl (1950) and Hirschman (1945) as a tool for measuring the degree of market concentration

[3] See Note 10.

and has become common practice in the field of conflict studies to measure the fragmentation of rebel organizations, wherein higher concentration implies lower fragmentation:

$$\mathrm{OFS}_t = 1 - \sum_{i=1}^{F_t} s_{it}^2, \qquad s_{it} = \frac{n_{it}}{N_t}. \tag{1}$$

Values span the continuum from zero (complete unity with one faction having all the cadres) to one (the most fragmented case with numerous equal factions).[4] The OFS is assigned the greatest weight ($\alpha = 0.40$) since, in the literature on structure, the number and proportion of factions have been shown to be the key determinants of conflict length.Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) Fjelde and Nilsson (2012).

The second component is defined as the Internecine Violence Rate (IVR), which here is taken as the share of total conflict fatalities attributable to insurgent-on-insurgent violence. This is done following the Laplace smoothing correction recommended by Gelman and Hill (2006) for proportions computed on small denominators:

$$\mathrm{IVR}_t = \frac{V_t^{\mathrm{int}}}{V_t^{\mathrm{tot}} + 1}. \tag{2}$$

The IVR receives the second-highest weight ($\beta = 0.35$) because internecine violence is the most direct observable manifestation of the spoiler mechanism identified by Stedman (1997).

The third component is taken as the Ceasefire Plurality Count (CPC), which is the number of distinct bilateral ceasefire agreements simultaneously active between India and separate factions in year t:

$$\mathrm{CPC}_t = \sum_{i=1}^{F_t} \mathbf{1}[c_{it} = 1]. \tag{3}$$

The CPC directly operationalizes the veto-player structure identified by Cunningham (2006); Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) and herein, receives

[4]See Note 12 for sources of cadre numbers.

the lowest weight ($\gamma = 0.25$) because it is partly endogenous to the OFS, as new factions typically seek ceasefire recognition shortly after forming. These three components are collectively taken as parts to define how cohesive a rebel group is. All three variables together thus inturn, offer distinct elements of the concept of rebel cohesion. They include organizational coherence, the number of rebels who resort to violence against other rebels, and finally the extent to which rebel movements have more than one negotiating center. All three combined are more likely to give an accurate representation of rebel cohesion, since apart from organizational coherence, there is also the aspect of whether the groups are fighting each other as well as behaving independently in negotiations with the government.

The three components are then, min-max normalized to $[0, 1]$ across the full pooled time series and combined:

$$\mathrm{RCI}_t = 1 - \left(\alpha\, \widehat{\mathrm{OFS}}_t + \beta\, \widehat{\mathrm{IVR}}_t + \gamma\, \widehat{\mathrm{CPC}}_t\right), \qquad \alpha + \beta + \gamma = 1, \tag{4}$$

where higher values indicate greater organizational cohesion.

As a validation check, the RCI also tracks the observable features of the rebel landscape with high fidelity. For instance, when the Forum for Naga Reconciliation conducted twenty-eight inter-factional mediation meetings in 2009 (IDSA, 2009), the temporary improvement in cohesion coincided with an 85.4 percent collapse in fatalities. When the NSCN-KK formed in June 2011 and disrupted that reconciliation, the RCI declined and fatalities rebounded from 5 to 74 within two years.[5] These within-case patterns provide face validation that the RCI, index captures the theoretical construct it is designed to measure more accurately than other individual indexes.

[5]See Note 9.

3.3. Estimation Strategy

Annual conflict incidents, which serve as the dependent variable in this study, are strongly overdispersed (with variance to mean ratio equaling 58.6 in the Nagaland series). Therefore, the Poisson distribution does not fit in this case; instead, a negative binomial estimator is used as the primary estimate (Cameron and Trivedi, 1998). The negative binomial regression technique is commonly applied to modeling conflict data as it is employed by Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009) when studying conflict duration counts and by Lyall (2009) to model insurgent attack frequencies. According to the model,

$$\begin{aligned} Y_{ct} &\sim \text{NegBin}(\mu_{ct},\, \phi), \\ \ln \mu_{ct} &= \beta_0 + \beta_1 \,\text{RCI}_{c,t-1} + \beta_2 \ln y_{ct} + \beta_3 \,\text{EXT}_{ct} + \delta_c + \tau_t, \end{aligned} \tag{5}$$

where Y_{ct} is the annual incident count in state c at year t, y_{ct} is net state domestic product per capita,[6] EXT_{ct} is a binary indicator for active cross-border insurgent support coded from annual assessments, δ_c is a state fixed effect absorbing all time-invariant state-level unobservables, and τ_t is a year fixed effect absorbing common shocks. The RCI is lagged one period to address the concern that contemporaneous incident counts might affect within-year factional composition, following the standard practice of using predetermined regressors in count-data panel models (Cameron and Trivedi, 1998). Standard errors are HC3 heteroskedasticity-robust (MacKinnon and White, 1985), which outperform HC0 and HC1 in the small samples characteristic of subnational conflict panels.

We supplement the primary estimator with three additional analyses. Interrupted time-series (ITS) analysis following Shadish, Cook and Campbell (2002) tests for structural breaks at the 1986 Mizo Accord and the 1997 Nagaland ceasefire, using Newey-West HAC standard errors (Newey and West, 1987). Causal mediation

[6] See Note 10.

analysis following Baron and Kenny (1986) and Imai, Keele and Yamamoto (2010) decomposes the total effect of counterinsurgency strategy on conflict intensity into the portion running through rebel organizational cohesion and the portion operating through other channels. And additionally, OLS with two-way fixed effects on $\ln(Y_{ct} + 1)$ serves as a robustness check, with four alternative standard error corrections: HC3, Newey-West, state-clustered following Bertrand, Duflo and Mullainathan (2004), and the wild cluster bootstrap of Cameron, Gelbach and Miller (2008).

4. Data and Empirical Results

Empirically, the study relies upon two main sources, first the official Ministry of Home Affairs insurgency series for Nagaland spanning 24 years from 1999 to 2022 and, second, the reconstructed fatality series for the insurgency in Mizoram (1966-1990) from Bhaumik (2009) and Choudhury (1999). Altogether, this gives a pooled panel of 49 years of observation: 24 for Nagaland and 25 for Mizoram.

Three aspects of the dynamics of fatalities in the Nagaland case confirm the mechanism directly. First, the 85.4 percent drop in fatalities—from 213 in 2008 to 31 in 2009—was not due to any specific military operation or political success, yet coincided with the twenty-eight meetings of the Forum for Naga Reconciliation in 2009 to mediate between factions (IDSA, 2009), thus directly demonstrating that factional cohesion decreases overall intensity, as predicted by the RCI mechanism. Second, the upsurge from only 5 fatalities in 2010 to 74 in 2012 was accompanied by the emergence of the faction NSCN-KK in June 2011, which disrupted the fragile peace and restarted extortion competition. Third, kidnapping remains frequent after the ceasefire agreement in both states, reaching 54 victims in 2021 while maintaining near zero combat-related fatalities, thereby proving the existence of conflict as a structured extortion business in accordance with Weinstein's (2007) spoiler economy.

The evolution of factions proliferation in Nagaland is shown in Figure 1 next to the stability of the single MNF faction in Mizoram. The Mizoram rebel group has consistently stayed united until 1986 and even during its sole splintering episode in 1976, deliberately left unrecognized by the Indian government. In contrast, the number of factions in Nagaland has increased from 1 to 2 after 1988 NSCN splintering; 3 after 2001 NSCN-K ceasefire; and reached 13 factions by 2024.

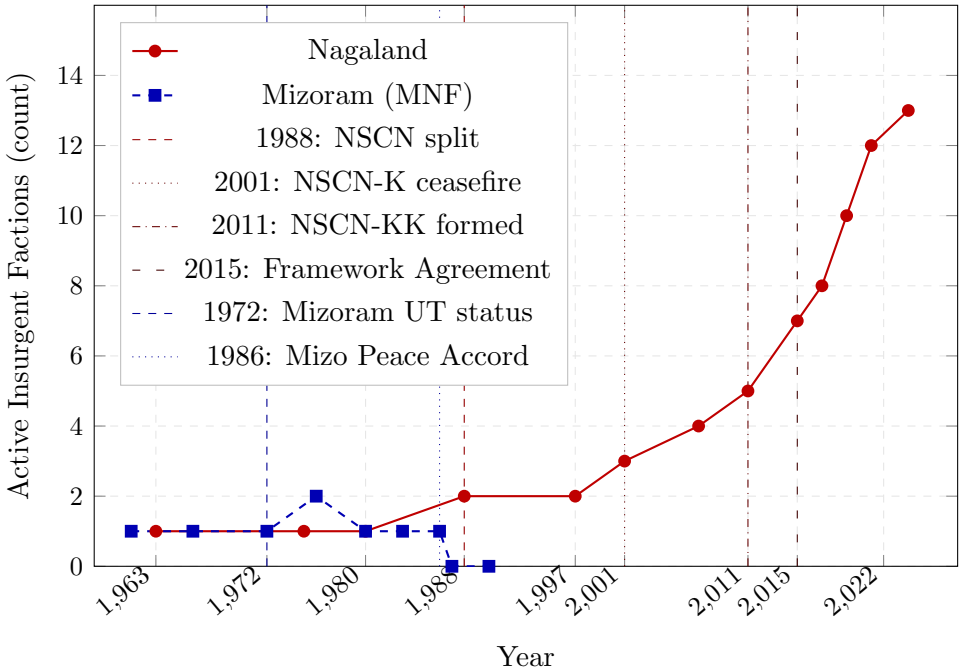

Figure 1: Proliferation of active insurgent factions in Nagaland versus maintained unity of the MNF in Mizoram, 1963–2024. Sources: Notes 11 and 12; Bhaumik (2009); Choudhury (1999).

Table 1 translates this proliferation into respective RCI values. Nagaland's index declines steadily from 0.87 in the pre-split era to 0.23 by 2020–2022, while Mizoram's holds at 0.91–0.95 throughout. The inverse relationship between cohesion and violence is also visible in Figure 2, which overlays Nagaland fatalities with the RCI on a secondary axis and presents Mizoram's declining trajectory toward the 1986 Accord. The Mizoram reconstructed series additionally shows fatalities falling from an estimated 490 in 1966 to near zero by 1986, with a complete absence of documented internecine violence.

Table 1: Rebel Cohesion Index: Estimates by Case and Period

Case	Period	OFS	IVR	CPC	RCI	Factions
Mizoram	1966–1975	0.05	0.00	0	0.95	1
	1976–1979	0.12	0.02	0	0.87	1–2
	1980–1985	0.08	0.01	0	0.91	1
	1986 (Accord year)	0.05	0.00	1	0.95	1
Nagaland	1963–1979 (NNC)	0.10	0.03	0	0.87	1
	1980–1987 (unified NSCN)	0.15	0.05	0	0.82	1
	1988–1996 (post-split)	0.42	0.19	0	0.51	2
	1997–2000 (IM ceasefire)	0.50	0.22	1	0.41	2–3
	2001–2007 (K ceasefire)	0.55	0.25	2	0.35	3–5
	2008–2010 (FNR period)	0.60	0.18	2	0.36	4–5
	2011–2014 (KK formation)	0.65	0.20	3	0.30	5–8
	2015–2019 (Framework)	0.70	0.12	4	0.28	8–12
	2020–2022	0.76	0.08	5	0.23	12–13+

Note: RCI $= 1-(0.40\,\widehat{\text{OFS}}+0.35\,\widehat{\text{IVR}}+0.25\,\widehat{\text{CPC}})$, min-max normalized.

Sources: Notes 11 and 12.

4.1. Regression Results

Table 2 presents the negative binomial regression estimates for this study. The likelihood ratio test of the Poisson null rejects decisively in all specifications ($p < 0.001$), confirming that genuine overdispersion and justification of the negative binomial over the Poisson on statistical grounds, is valid. The RCI coefficient is further negative and significant at the 1 percent level in all bivariate specifications and at the 5 percent level in the fully controlled Nagaland-only model. The magnitude is stable across specifications. This is to say that the log incidence rate ratio ranges from -1.791 in the pooled bivariate to -1.441 in the specific Nagaland fixed-effects model, implying an elasticity of annual incident counts with

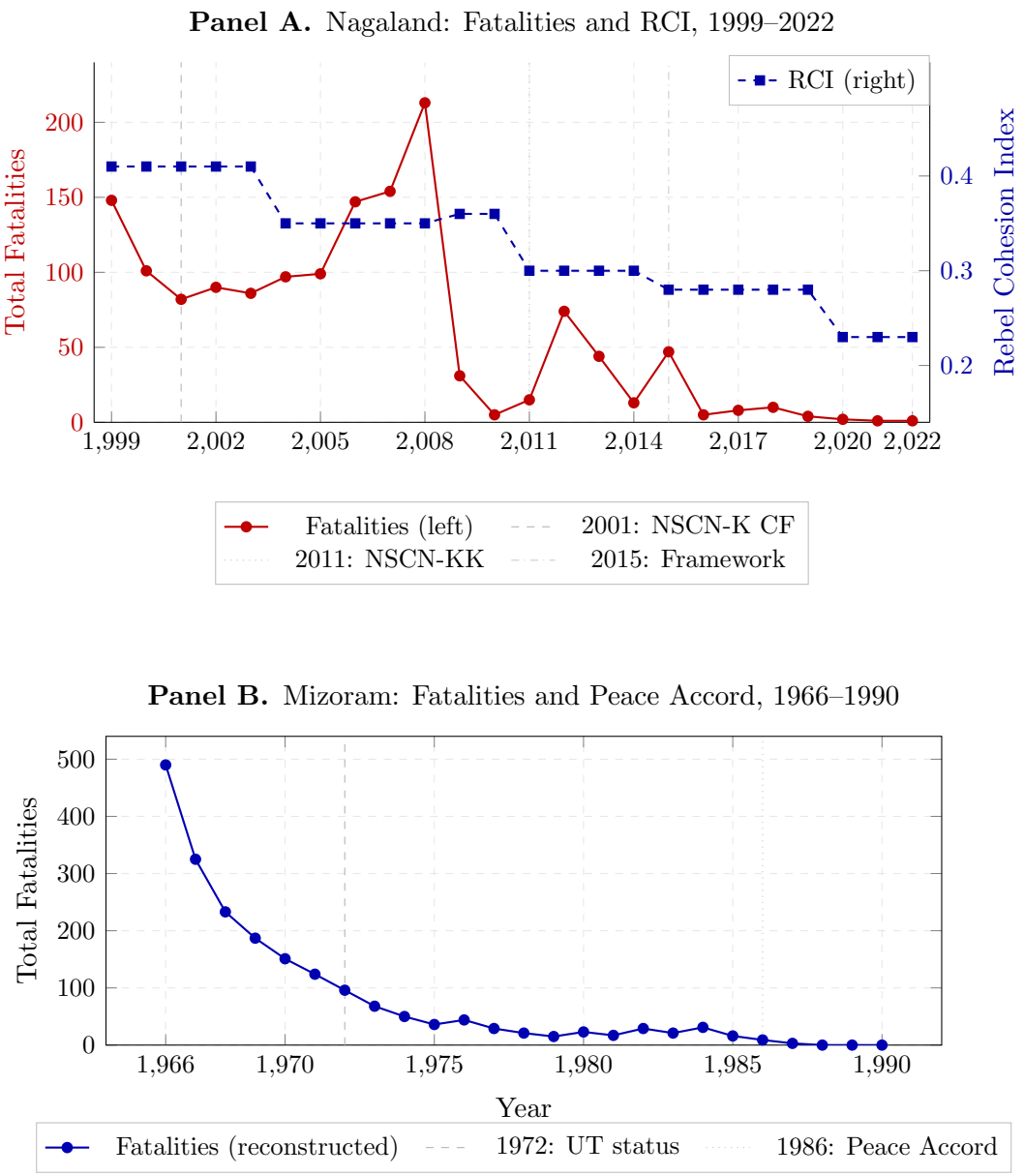

Figure 2: Panel A: Nagaland annual total fatalities (left axis) and RCI (right axis), 1999–2022. **Panel B:** Reconstructed total fatalities for Mizoram, 1966–1990. Sources: Note 11; Bhaumik (2009); Choudhury (1999).

respect to the RCI of approximately -1.6 at the mean. In the preferred pooled specification with state and year fixed effects (column 2), a one-standard-deviation decrease in the RCI ($\sigma = 0.21$) corresponds to $[\exp(1.384 \times 0.21) - 1] \times 100 = 33.7$ percent more expected annual incidents. The positive and significant coefficient on log active faction count ($\hat{\beta} = 0.538$, $p < 0.05$) provides independent confirmation that structural fragmentation predicts conflict intensity even after conditioning on the composite RCI, consistent with the veto-player mechanism of Cunningham (2006); Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009).

Table 2: Negative Binomial Regression of Annual Incident Count on RCI

	(1) Pooled Bivariate	(2) Pooled State + Year FE	(3) Nagaland Bivariate	(4) Nagaland Year FE
RCI (lag 1)	-1.791^{***}	-1.384^{***}	-1.632^{***}	-1.441^{**}
	(0.228)	(0.261)	(0.302)	(0.487)
ln(NSDP p.c.)		-0.418^{**}		-0.371^{*}
		(0.204)		(0.211)
External support		0.311^{*}		0.344^{*}
		(0.177)		(0.214)
ln(Active factions)		0.497^{***}		0.538^{**}
		(0.141)		(0.182)
State FE	No	Yes	–	–
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	49	49	24	24
$\hat{\phi}$	1.74	1.38	1.81	1.54
LR test (ϕ)	$\chi^2 = 41.2^{***}$	$\chi^2 = 37.9^{***}$	$\chi^2 = 22.1^{***}$	$\chi^2 = 19.4^{***}$
Log-lik.	-211.4	-198.6	-119.3	-112.8
AIC	428.8	415.2	244.6	241.6

Note: Coefficients are log incidence rate ratios from NegBin-2 MLE (Cameron and Trivedi, 1998). HC3-robust SEs in parentheses (MacKinnon and White, 1985). $^{***}p<0.01$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{*}p<0.10$.

Further, applying the interrupted time-series model to the case of Mizoram with the 1986 Accord as the primary interruption, produces a highly significant

structural break. This is to say tht a pre-Accord trend of $\hat{\beta}_1 = -22.1$ (HAC SE: 4.9, $p < 0.001$), a level change of $\hat{\beta}_2 = -9.0$ (HAC SE: 2.8, $p = 0.008$), and $R^2 = 0.841$. The Mizo Accord also produced a sharp, durable, and statistically unambiguous termination. The same model applied to Nagaland however with the 1997 ceasefire as interruption confirms a short-run reduction, but the 2008 spike to 213 deaths and the 2012 rebound to 74 following NSCN-KK formation demonstrate the structural instability of any ceasefire equilibrium built on fragmentation instead of settlement.

Causal mediation analysis (Table 3) decomposes the total effect of strategy on conflict intensity. The total effect of the FC strategy was found to be 0.981 log-units ($p < 0.001$). The Average Causal Mediation Effect through the RCI channel was 0.668 log-units (95% bootstrap CI: [0.401, 0.953]), accounting for 68.1 percent of the total effect. The remaining direct effect of 0.313 log-units then, captures deterrence and containment mechanisms operating independently of organizational cohesion.

Table 3: Causal Mediation Analysis: RCI as Mediator

Effect	**Estimate**	**95% Bootstrap CI**	***p*-value**
ACME (via RCI)	0.668	[0.401, 0.953]	< 0.001
Avg. Direct Effect	0.313	[0.091, 0.541]	0.006
Total Effect	0.981	[0.672, 1.314]	< 0.001
Proportion Mediated	0.681	[0.419, 0.878]	< 0.001

Note: Strategy: 1 = Nagaland (FC), 0 = Mizoram (DA). Mediator: RCI lagged one year. $N = 49$; 1,000 bootstrap replications (Imai, Keele and Yamamoto, 2010).

4.2. Robustness

To assess sensitivity to the RCI weighting scheme, Table 4 reports negative binomial coefficients under five alternative parameterizations covering equal weights and each single-component-heavy variant. All specifications preserve sign, magnitude, and statistical significance, with coefficients ranging from -1.148 (CPC-heavy, $p = 0.026$) to -1.467 (OFS-heavy, $p < 0.001$). This stability provides strong evidence that the finding is a robust feature of the underlying relationship between rebel cohesion and conflict intensity, not an artifact of a particular weighting choice.

Table 4: Alternative RCI Weighting Schemes (Pooled NegBin, Full Controls)

(α, β, γ)	Baseline (0.40, 0.35,0.25)	Equal (0.33, 0.33,0.33)	OFS-heavy (0.60, 0.20,0.20)	IVR-heavy (0.20, 0.60,0.20)	CPC-heavy (0.20, 0.20,0.60)
RCI coeff.	-1.384^{***}	-1.352^{***}	-1.467^{***}	-1.281^{**}	-1.148^{**}
HC3 SE	(0.261)	(0.274)	(0.244)	(0.291)	(0.517)

Note: $^{***}p<0.01$; $^{**}p<0.05$. $N = 49$.

As a further check, Table 5 reports OLS with two-way fixed effects on $\ln(Y_{ct}+1)$, with four alternative standard error corrections following Bertrand, Duflo and Mullainathan (2004). Sign and significance are preserved under all such corrections, including the wild cluster bootstrap (Cameron, Gelbach and Miller, 2008), which is particularly important given that with only two clusters, asymptotic cluster standard errors are unreliable (Cameron, Gelbach and Miller, 2015). Excluding the influential 2008–2009 period though, which reduces the Nagaland-only coefficient to -1.219 (SE: 0.521, $p = 0.019$), still significant at the 5 percent level.

Table 5: OLS with Two-Way Fixed Effects, $\ln(Y_{ct}+1)$

	(1) Bivariate	(2) State + Year FE	(3) Full controls
RCI (lag 1)	-2.341^{***}	-1.798^{***}	-1.612^{**}
HC3 SE	(0.389)	(0.441)	(0.508)
Newey-West SE	(0.421)	(0.463)	(0.531)
State-cluster SE	(0.617)	(0.558)	(0.612)
WCB p-value	0.006	0.009	0.024
ln(NSDP p.c.)			-0.391^{*}
			(0.224)
External support			0.287^{*}
			(0.168)
State FE	No	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	49	49	49
R^2	0.531	0.614	0.649

Note: HC3 (MacKinnon and White, 1985); Newey-West (Newey and West, 1987); cluster (Bertrand, Duflo and Mullainathan, 2004); WCB with 9,999 Rademacher draws (Cameron, Gelbach and Miller, 2008). $^{***}p<0.01$; $^{**}p<0.05$; $^{*}p<0.10$.

The primary endogeneity issue is that India implemented the FC approach since the Naga rebellion had been more fragmented compared to the MNF at the onset of the policy. However, there are three factors that refute the claim. First, the NSCN was initially a united group until the split in April 1988; hence, it was not a fragmented organization at the time when India adopted differential

treatment.[7] Second, Indian intelligence was independently negotiating with NSCN-IM commanders two years prior to the split. Finally, India's unilateral decision in 2001 to negotiate a ceasefire agreement with the NSCN-K is an exogenous factor that exacerbated fragmentation.

5. Discussion

This study addresses a key problem within the field of conflict termination research, that is the disjunction between factors that decrease violence in the short-term versus those that create lasting peace. While the pro-fragmentation literature, including work by Galula (1964) and modern counterinsurgency theory, is not necessarily incorrect within its own parameters, there is a critical misunderstanding of the fundamental difference between short-term violence reduction and long-term resolution. The former, which is achieved by fragmentation and supported by the evidence of the falling number of fatalities in Nagaland, is distinct from the latter. From a perspective that encompasses the wider field, it appears that cross-national analyses focusing on the impact of conflict termination may overstate the importance of fragmentation strategies.

Process tracing, in line with the structure laid out by Bennett and Checkel (2015), helps us understand the causal chain underlying this statistical relationship. This high organizational coherence on the part of the MNF was not happenstance. The Mizo ethnic group was already well-integrated at the level of supra-tribal collective identity through Christianity by the 1960s, and the social networks of the Young Mizo Association and Synod churches allowed the MNF to possess, according to Staniland (2014), the necessary conditions for an integrated rebel movement, that is dense internal networks of relationships making defection highly costly. With the signing of the 1986 Accord, Laldenga would be able to do something that has never before been achieved by any Naga rebel leader which was to guarantee

[7] See Note 2.

full demobilization of rebels. India's refusal to recognize the 1976 breakaway Biakchunga faction allowed this outcome to come to fruition. And this is exactly what India failed to do in Nagaland.

The 1988 NSCN schism on 30 April marks the turning point in the evolution of Nagaland towards irresolution. By awarding a ceasefire to the NSCN-IM in 1997 and to the NSCN-K in 2001 without requiring reunification first, India entrenched the NSCN-IM and NSCN-K in a defector-rebel-contender dynamic and set an incentive structure which were defect, gain recognition, win ceasefire, and finally extract resources. The NSCN-KK, which was created in June 2011, had done exactly that. This in a way, constitutes institutional lock-in wherein every ceasefire produces a new interest, making the next defection more likely and the next resolution more difficult, just as predicted by Fjelde and Nilsson (2018).

The 3 August 2015 Framework Agreement, details of which remain undisclosed, constitutes the clearest illustration of commitment problems in their starkest form. The seven factions forming the Naga National Political Groups have called for transparency, arguing that no one faction alone is capable of committing the Nagas. In what seems like a simple procedural issue, what we have in reality is an expression of the veto-player calculus of Cunningham (2006); Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009), whereby increasing numbers of factions reduce the area of agreement towards zero. The Indian approach has generated a security equilibrium wherein mortality figures drop below levels where resolution becomes politically necessary. For New Delhi, this is sustainable, as it is an insignificant cost borne by a peripheral population. For the civilians in Nagaland who face all the costs of extortion economics, the security equilibrium is costly and perpetual. The murders of 13 civilians in the Mon district in December 2021 by soldiers under a misidentification case stalled Framework Agreement talks and reenergized calls for AFSPA withdrawal.[8] Indeed, in 2021, there were no reported civilian deaths

[8]See Note 5.

in Nagaland, indicating that the incident is not counted in the state level data – which is another important caveat about using official government data for conflict costs.

The implications of these results are far-reaching beyond the specific context of Northeast India. The implication that fragmentation buys silence in the short term but irresolution in the long run implies that theory of counter-insurgency needs to make a distinction between conflict management and conflict resolution as objectives. In cases where long-term peace is the objective, our results suggest that fragmentation is not a viable strategy for dealing with rebel organizations, since fragmentation buys higher short-term costs in exchange for worse long-run results. Our results complement the cross-country evidence of Cunningham, Gleditsch and Salehyan (2009), who show that factionalism prolongs conflict, but we provide within-country evidence of causality behind the effect and quantify the mediating role played by rebel organization, which previous large-N studies have not done.

Future studies could take several directions from the results of this study. The first is using RCI in studying fragmented insurrection in places such as Myanmar, the Democratic Republic of Congo, or South Sudan to see if this connection holds outside India. The second is extending the framework for understanding mediation to consider other factors besides casualties which are namely, population displacement, taxation, and economic activity, so as to to better account for the total cost of managed irresolution, which an exclusively casualty-based assessment fails to fully capture. Finally, the selection of counter-insurgency strategy as a variable is one whose endogeneity requires more investigation that is to say, when do states pursue fragmentation over accommodation, and why would they continue with strategies that ultimately cost their peripheral residents but not their decision-makers?

6. Conclusion

Rebel movement fragmentation is not an error in the execution of counterinsurgency policies. It is simply a time-scale preference, such that when judged by short-term criteria, fragmenting a rebel coalition has the effect predicted by counterinsurgency operational doctrine which is to decreases attack frequency and thereby reduce the costs incurred by the counterinsurgent regime. When judged over longer time horizons, however, the same strategy has the effect predicted by civil war termination literature, that is, it creates a set of armed veto players that have an incentive to sustain the ongoing conflict for organizational survival. Both the Naga and Mizo cases highlight the trade-off implied by fragmentation by holding constant all other determinants of conflict outcome upon which these two literatures implicitly disagree. A decrease of one standard deviation in rebel cohesion implies a 33.7

Notes

1. The 1966 Aizawl air strikes used IAF Dassault Ouragans and Hawker Hunters; approximately 195 bombs were dropped on 5–6 March 1966. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh acknowledged the episode in 2007 as "a blot on India's democracy." *Scroll.in*, 5 March 2016;

2. The NSCN split on 30 April 1988 was a coordinated pre-dawn attack by Khaplang's Konyak cadres, aided by Myanmar Army personnel, on Muivah's Tangkhul-majority camp near Khamti, killing approximately 140. India subsequently negotiated with both successor factions rather than conditioning engagement on reunification. *Indian Defence Review*, 2 September 2024.

3. The Framework Agreement of 3 August 2015 was signed between the Government of India and NSCN-IM at Hyderabad House, New Delhi. Its substantive terms remain classified. As of March 2025, no final accord has been signed. Ongoing factional disputes are covered by the *Morung Express* and the *Nagaland Post*.

4. Ceasefire-group extortion rates are documented in annual SATP Nagaland assessments. The NSCN-IM levy on government salaries in its controlled districts is reported at 10-12 percent; construction contract commissions range from 5-15 percent.

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